

Integrity

You now know how AI works and how to use it well. Two habits decide whether that knowledge actually helps you. The first is honesty.

AI is an incredibly powerful tool for learning. But there's a difference between **using AI to learn** and **using AI to skip learning**. The line isn't always obvious, so let's make it clear.

WHERE THE LINE IS



Submitting AI output as your own work

Copying AI-generated text, code, or answers and putting your name on it. This is plagiarism, even if you edited a few words.



Using AI on assignments that prohibit it

If your teacher says no AI, that means no AI. Violating this is academic dishonesty, even if you think the rule is unfair.



Using AI to generate ideas, then doing the work yourself

Generally acceptable, but check your teacher's policy. Be transparent about what you used AI for if asked.



Using AI to explain concepts you don't understand

Like having a tutor. This is usually fine and actually helps you learn. But don't let it replace actually working through problems.



Using AI to review and improve your own work

You did the thinking. AI gives feedback. This is like asking a friend to proofread your essay. The work is still yours.



Using AI to learn a topic, then demonstrating understanding yourself

Research with AI, understand the material, write/present/solve in your own words. The learning happened. That's the whole point.

The yellow zone is the tricky one. The same AI use can be fine in one class and not okay in another. The assignment's rules decide.



If you can't explain it, defend it, or reproduce the thinking, it isn't really your work.

The teacher-without-notes test still applies. Could you walk through it cold? If not, AI did the work for you. And one more test catches almost everything: if you'd be embarrassed to say out loud how you used AI, that's your answer.

PLAGIARISM VS COPYRIGHT

Plagiarism and copyright sound similar, but they answer different questions. Get the difference clear before you submit, post, or sell anything you used AI to make.

PLAGIARISM

Did you pretend someone else's work was yours?

About honesty.

COPYRIGHT

Were you allowed to use or copy that work?

About rights.

STAYING OUT OF TROUBLE



'AI made it' doesn't automatically mean 'I own it.'

Different apps have different terms. Some grant you commercial rights to your outputs, some restrict them. Check before you sell, post, or submit anything that's going to make money or live somewhere public.



Do the real work yourself and it's yours.

Brainstorm characters with AI, then write the story yourself, and the story is yours. AI was an ingredient, not the author. The work you actually do is the work you own.



Rewriting someone's work doesn't make it yours.

Upload a copyrighted article, ask AI to reword it, and you get a copy in new clothes, not a new work. The rights still belong to whoever wrote the original.



'In the style of [real person]' gets risky fast.

Especially if the person is alive, the style is tied to a recognizable brand, or you're using the result commercially. School project poster: usually fine. T-shirts you're selling on Etsy: not fine.

SHOW YOUR PROCESS

Some schools run student work through AI detectors. They sound official. They're not as reliable as they sound. They produce both false positives (honest work flagged as AI) and false negatives (real AI use missed). A detector score isn't proof by itself, and the arms race favors the generators.

So don't bet your grade on a tool's accuracy. Build a defense the detector can't take from you: a visible record of how the work actually came together. What you keep is your call. The point is that some trail exists if you ever need it. A few examples:



Drafts as you go

Save versions, not just the final. The path from rough to polished is itself the proof.



Sources with links and dates

Copy the URL and the date for anything you read or watched. Real research leaves a trail. AI hallucinations don't.



AI conversation logs

Keep your prompts and the AI's replies. If your work is ever questioned, you can show exactly how you used AI.



The best defense isn't hoping the detector believes you. It's having the receipts.

DISCLOSING YOUR AI USE

Whether you have to cite AI, and in what format, is your school's call. Check your teacher's rule first, and follow current APA, MLA, or Chicago guidance if they require it. What doesn't change is the honest move: a short note saying what you used AI for. Here's what a plain disclosure note can look like, adapt it to your situation:

Brainstorming

I used ChatGPT to brainstorm possible essay structures. I wrote the final draft myself.

Use when AI helped you explore ideas but you did the writing yourself.

Debugging code or fixing errors

I used Claude to debug my code and explain the error.

Use when AI helped you find or fix mistakes, but the work is yours.

Practice and review

I used Gemini to generate practice questions for review.

Use when AI made study material for you, like flashcards or quiz questions.



Always disclose what you used AI for

Even if citation isn't required, add a note: "I used Claude to help brainstorm ideas for this essay" or "AI was used to debug my code." Transparency builds trust.



When in doubt, ask your teacher

AI policies vary by school, class, and assignment. If the rules aren't clear, ask before you submit. It's easier to get permission than forgiveness.

WHEN OTHER PEOPLE ARE IN THE LOOP

In group work, agree on AI use before anyone uses it. If one person silently AI-drafts a section, the others can't review it the way they would human work, can't catch mistakes, and didn't get to weigh in on whether to use AI at all. Hidden AI use changes the work for everyone.



AI can help you learn, draft, debug, and revise. But your name goes on the work only when you understand it, can defend it, and followed the rules.

TRY IT

Real situations you'll face. For each one, pick the approach you think is best, then see how it lands.